

Dirassat & Abhath
The Arabic Journal of Human
and Social Sciences



مجلة دراسات وأبحاث
المجلة العربية في العلوم الإنسانية
والاجتماعية

EISSN: 2253-0363
ISSN : 1112-9751

**Deconstructing the Discourse of Power and the Power of Discourse: An
Analysis of the Covert Systems in Ibn Khaldun's Travelogue**

تفكيك خطاب السّلاطة وسلطة الخطاب:

قراءة في الأنساق المضمرّة لرحلة ابن خلدون

Meriem BOUZERDA

Associate Professor, Higher Education College for Teachers ASSIA DJEBBAR (Constantine)/
Algeria, Department of Arabic Language and Literature, Laboratory of Arabic narrative,
bouzerda.meriem@ensc.dz

مريم بوزردة،

أستاذ محاضر (أ)، المدرسة العليا للأساتذة آسيا جبّار (قسنطينة) / الجزائر، قسم اللغة والأدب العربي،

مخبر السّرد العربي.

bouzerda.meriem@ensc.dz

تاريخ القبول : 2025/12/27

تاريخ الاستلام: 2025/09/20

Abstract:

This study investigates the latent cultural structures of power within Ibn Khaldun's travelogue, (Autobiography of Ibn Khaldun and his Journey East and West). It re-examines the work from a cultural perspective, considering it a political discourse that reproduces the image of authority through various mechanisms. The research employs a sociological-cultural critique, drawing on Foucault's concepts of the microphysics of power, Bourdieu's theories of symbolic capital, Gramsci's ideas on the organic intellectual, and Hicham Sharabi's theses on the patriarchal system.

The findings reveal that power in the travelogue is not merely hierarchical but a complex, interconnected network exercised through multiple apparatuses: the inner circle and informants, intellectuals and discourse, and the sacralization of authority alongside the politicization of religion. Everyone, it appears, is complicit in the game of power, whether consciously or not. The study highlights how Ibn Khaldun, as an organic intellectual, leveraged his symbolic and cultural capital, translating his intellectual position into a form of authority. He employed his discourse to both serve and resist power at different times. In doing so, the travelogue exposes the multifaceted nature of power, demonstrating that it is exercised by all individuals and institutions within society.

Keywords: Power; Cultural Critique; Discourse of Power; Symbolic Capital; Khaldunian Discourse.

المخلص:

تهدف هذه الدراسة إلى استقراء الأنساق الثقافية المضمرة للسلطة في رحلة "التعريف بابن خلدون ورحلته غرباً وشرقاً"، وإعادة قراءتها ثقافياً بوصفها خطاباً سياسياً يعيد إنتاج صورة السلطة عبر آليات مختلفة. تعتمد الدراسة على منهج النقد الثقافي السوسيولوجي، مستفيدة من مفاهيم فوكو في ميكروفيزياء السلطة، ونظريات بورديو في الرأسمال الرمزي، وتنظيرات غرامشي حول المثقف العضوي، وأطروحات هشام شرابي في النظام الأبوي. كشفت النتائج أن السلطة في الرحلة ليست هرمية فحسب، بل شبكة متداخلة تمارس عبر أجهزة متعددة: البطانة والوشاية، المثقف والخطاب، تدين السلطة وتسييس الدين، حيث يظهر الجميع متورطين في لعبة السلطة بوعي أو دون وعي. تبرز الدراسة كيف استثمار ابن خلدون رأسماله الرمزي والثقافي كمثقف عضوي، مترجماً موقعه المعرفي إلى قوة سلطوية، وموظفاً خطابه لخدمة السلطة تارة ومقاومتها تارة أخرى. وبذلك تكشف الرحلة عن الوجه الآخر للسلطة بجميع أجهزتها، في كونها تمارس من طرف جميع الأفراد والأجهزة في المجتمع.

الكلمات المفتاحية: السلطة؛ النقد الثقافي؛ خطاب السلطة؛ الرأسمال الرمزي؛ الخطاب الخلدوني.

INTRODUCTION

Travel literature is a genre that has long been a part of Arab literary tradition and is considered one of its richest forms. It did not merely document information or describe places, nature, and geographical regions. Instead, travel discourse was imbued with

cultural, intellectual, religious, and political dimensions. Even when the purpose of a journey was pilgrimage, the pursuit of knowledge, diplomatic alliances, or embassies, it was directly or indirectly shaped by the structures of power.

A prime example of a travel text subject to such power dynamics during the Middle Islamic period is the journey of Abd al-Rahman Ibn Khaldun (d. 808 AH), titled *Al-Ta'rif bi-Ibn Khaldun wa Riḥlatuh Gharban wa Sharqan* (Autobiography of Ibn Khaldun and his Journey East and West). It is not just an autobiography but a record of political experiences, in which the author recounts the affairs of states, the policies of rulers and sultans, and the calamities that befell Muslims—from the fall of Al-Andalus in the west to the Mongol invasions in the east. Ibn Khaldun was also sent on sensitive diplomatic missions by rulers and served as a mediator between warring factions. This makes the travelogue rich with representations of political, religious, social, and cultural authority. Consequently, the travelogue is not a neutral text. Its author was influenced by external forces, including the authority of the ruler, the customs of others, foreign systems of government, the military, religion, and the judiciary. The text thus transcends a simple narrative of travel and transforms into a complex network that reveals the mechanisms of power in its various forms during that historical era.

Based on this, Ibn Khaldun's text becomes a living document that exposes the intricate web of relationships between authority and its tools. The author did not merely record the political reality of the countries he visited; he also provided analyses that demonstrate his profound understanding of the structure and mechanisms of power.

Studying how power operates within the travelogue allows for a re-reading of the text not merely as an autobiography but as a cultural and political discourse that reproduces the image of authority. This underscores the significance of this research,

which aims to culturally approach and interrogate power, its apparatuses, and its tools to articulate what is left unsaid and to question the latent structures of power. This is done in accordance with Michel Foucault's vision of power and his theories on the discourse of power and the power of discourse, as well as the theories of Bourdieu and Gramsci concerning the intellectual, and the ideas of the Palestinian thinker Hicham Sharabi on the patriarchal system of governance. This approach moves beyond the usual studies of travelogues, which focus on narrative, the self-other relationship, the description of place, or the wondrous, by providing a socio-cultural analysis.

From this perspective, the following questions arise:

Does power in the travelogue represent a hierarchical, patriarchal authority? If it is not hierarchical, did it possess specific apparatuses and tools during the Middle Islamic period? What was the traveler's position in relation to power? Was he a pawn in the hands of authority, or did he break free from its influence? If he did, did he use his knowledge and culture to exercise a symbolic power that reshaped the concept of authority? Finally, how did Ibn Khaldun portray the judiciary as an institution of power? These questions make power within the travelogue a fertile ground for research and analysis, revealing the political, historical, cultural, and social depth of the text and showcasing the representations and tools of power in North Africa, Al-Andalus, and Egypt.

1. Ibn Khaldun's Travelogue and the Problem of Genre Classification

Upon reading Ibn Khaldun's travelogue, the first thing that strikes the reader is the first part of the title: *Al-Ta'rif bi-Ibn Khaldūn* (Autobiography of Ibn Khaldun). This title immediately indicates

the author's primary goal: to provide a self-biography, which positions the travelogue at the intersection of autobiographical writing, a genre well-known in classical Arabic literature. The second part of the title, *wa Rihlatuh Gharban wa Sharqan* (and his Journey East and West), with the suffixed pronoun “-h” (his), refers back to the traveler. Thus, the work is a self-biography in which Ibn Khaldun describes his travels and his shifting positions across the Islamic lands of that time. This raises the question: What is the relationship between autobiography and the travelogue?

A traveler records their movements from one place to another and, as a result, details their life and daily experiences in their travelogue. This is the common ground between the two genres. As Nawal Abd al-Rahman al-Shawbakah states, "Travel literature is a vibrant art form, rich with lived experiences, movement, and transition from one place to another. In this sense, it intersects with biography, as the word *sāra* (to travel) indicates movement and transition, hinting at a long journey, covering distances, and multiple stages. This aligns with writings that chronicle a person's life from childhood to old age."¹ The travelogue, therefore, reveals the author's route and the experiences they had during their travels, clarifying the close ties between the two literary forms.

This type of work suggests with some certainty that the author intended to highlight their academic and intellectual standing in their time. The self-biography in these cases is a means of demonstrating prestige and pride in the positions and ranks the traveler held and the places they visited due to their status.

However, the reader's expectations are often subverted. While one might anticipate a description of the customs of various peoples,

or of architecture and nature, the text instead provides an account of the political conditions that characterized these lands and the shifting fortunes of Muslims, kings, princes, and figures of authority. It recounts imprisonments, exiles, murders, the fall of states, the rise of others, military attacks, diplomatic peace, the removal of an emir or a judge, and the tyranny of others. The underlying motive for these events is the love of power, prestige, and influence. Thus, Ibn Khaldun's travelogue is not an ordinary journey undertaken for a religious, scholarly, commercial, or recreational purpose, describing people ethnographically, anthropologically, and geographically. Instead, he dedicated it to his life experiences and profound intellectual reflections on politics, social life, human civilization, and the rise and fall of states. It functions as an appendix to his book *Al-Ibar*, which he revised and added to, with the final additions made just before his death. The Moroccan scholar Muhammad ibn Tawit al-Tanji (1918–1974) later edited the work, relying on Ibn Khaldun's original manuscripts and comparing them for his edition, as noted in his introduction ².

A reader of Ibn Khaldun's travelogue quickly realizes that the text blends several literary forms: autobiography, heterobiography, memoirs, poetry, speeches, letters, proverbs, aphorisms, and historical accounts. This places us in the midst of a critical problem that remains unresolved: the issue of classifying travel literature into a single, specific literary genre. This is a very difficult task for a genre whose very names are diverse—memoirs, geographical literature, travel literature, or tourism literature—not to mention the variety of discourses it contains. The problem stems from the fact that each literary genre has its

own distinct characteristics. For example, oratory has its unique qualities, different from an essay, a story, or a proverb. Travel discourse, however, possesses numerous characteristics that vary with its generic diversity. Some researchers argue that classifying travel literature into a single category is an injustice, as it is a text that transcends categorization. As some critics observe, travel literature cannot be confined to a specific literary type; rather, it is a text that breaks the law of generic purity. Travel literature is a "holistic genre that breaks the law of generic purity by integrating diverse discursive patterns in terms of forms and contents" ³. It is a "trans-genre or a non-genre, and perhaps we can even say that it is a collector of genres" ⁴. Therefore, it can be argued that travel literature is a literary genre with its own unique characteristics.

2. The Definition of Power

The Arabic word for authority, *sulta* (سلطة), derives from the verb *salata*, which conveys a sense of coercion and power. In classical usage, related terms like *sult* and *salit* describe someone with a sharp tongue or powerful, eloquent speech. For instance, a salient person is described as persuasive and commanding⁵. The term *sultan* also relates to this root, signifying both a ruler and the proof or evidence of his legitimacy, as he is considered God's proof on Earth. This definition highlights that authority is essentially the ruler's power.

According to the Philosophical Dictionary by Jamil Saliba, authority is defined as "the capacity and power over something." The plural form, *sultat* (سلطات), refers to the social apparatuses that exercise this power, such as political, educational, religious, and judicial authorities⁶. Thus, the linguistic meaning of the term revolves around coercion, dominance, and a power

that enables a person to impose their opinion and stance on others.

In a more technical sense, M.G. Smith defines authority as the "ability to effectively influence people and things, using a series of means ranging from persuasion to coercion."⁷ This definition underscores that authority's influence is derived from its capacity to sway individuals, whether through voluntary consent or by force.

The concept of power has evolved from one historical period to another according to the factors and influences that shaped its form within society. In the ancient Near East, power was viewed as subject to the cosmic order, and the ruler was considered a divine being or a representative of the gods, tasked with managing and controlling the affairs of the universe. Here, power was cosmic, ruled by the gods. In the Greek era, it was viewed from the perspective of the ideal city, subject to ethics, reason, and philosophy. In the Roman era, it derived its legitimacy from the power of legislation due to the vastness of the empire. It, therefore, relied on laws to preserve its legacy. Among Arabs in the pre-Islamic era, the tribal chief derived his power from his prestige and status, which enabled him to control the members of the tribe. In the Middle Ages, power was derived from the Church, which granted indulgences to its allies and executed and ostracized its opponents. The modern era has based its legitimacy on the people, who choose their ruler themselves. However, it is a power based on force and control over the populace, which leads us to say that power is "inherent to temporality, as there is no temporal stage or historical era that can be excluded from its existence and active presence. This is because it is fundamentally based on a shared life. Moreover, power alone is capable of ensuring the 'duration' and continuity of the

shared world" ⁸. In general, the meaning of power is the extension of influence, dominance, and the exercise of coercion from top to bottom; that is, it is a hierarchical, patriarchal authority that knows the common good, monitors actions to avoid error, and maintains stability.

In the Islamic eras, power took on the meaning of *al-wilayah* (governance), i.e., the governor, the Imam, the Caliph, or the Sultan. Governance was divided into two types: general and specific. The general type is what its holder performs on behalf of the public, while the specific type is related to the governance of the family, such as the parents' care for their children. Therefore, general governance, the Imamate, the Caliphate, or the rule of Muslims, has close ties to power, as it is linked to the care of Muslim affairs. The early Islamic scholars defined political power as "the Imamate placed as a succession to the Prophethood in guarding religion and managing worldly affairs" ⁹. The subjects must obey the Caliph chosen by covenant or allegiance, as they "should entrust public matters to him without usurping his authority or opposing him so that he can carry out the interests and management entrusted to him" ¹⁰. The political power of the Caliph or Sultan was thus viewed with a sense of sanctity.

At its beginning, Islamic political power was based on consultation (*shura*) between the ruler and the ruled, based on the Quranic verse: "And that those who dispute concerning Our signs may know that for them there is no escape." (Ash-Shura, 35), and also: "So by a mercy from Allah, [O Muhammad], you were lenient with them. And if you had been rude [in speech] and harsh in heart, they would have disbanded from about you. So pardon them and ask forgiveness for them and consult them in the matter. And when you have decided, then

rely upon Allah. Indeed, Allah loves those who rely [upon Him]."(Al Imran, 159). After the death of the Prophet, Muslims continued to follow the principle of consultation in choosing their leader through allegiance (*bay'ah*), and the people were committed to obeying their command based on the verse "Indeed, Allah commands you to render trusts to whom they are due and when you judge between people to judge with justice. Excellent is that which Allah instructs you. Indeed, Allah is ever Hearing and Seeing." (An-Nisa, 58). On this basis, power was not hierarchical but distributed between the ruler and the ruled in a way that served their interests. This type of rule continued until the death of the last Rightly Guided Caliph, Ali ibn Abi Talib, in the year 40 AH. With the establishment of the Umayyad state, political power transitioned to the choice of the ruler/Caliph through inheritance or covenant, and they used force and the sword to enforce this right. Rule shifted from a consultative, participatory system to a hierarchical, hereditary one. They relied on religion to legitimize their rule and sanctify the Caliph, making obedience to him a duty and rebellion a transgression against the command of God and the Prophet. This view of power and governance continued until the fall of the Ottoman Empire and the occupation of most Arab-Islamic countries, where power became a despotic authority based on centralized domination and the marginalization of the Arab and Islamic people in governance by the colonizer. After independence, these countries adopted Western theories of governance and power.

Until recently, power was viewed on this basis: a system built on centralization, superiority, and a hierarchical rule that flows from top to bottom. This perspective was challenged by the French philosopher Michel

Foucault (1926–1984), who reformulated its concept entirely.

Michel Foucault created a rupture with previous notions of power as a hierarchical, purely political phenomenon. He based his theories on his archaeological method and the ideas of the philosopher Nietzsche. Foucault did not seek to define the essence of power but rather to understand how it operates and is realized in society. He concluded that power is exercised in the margins—in prisons, the judiciary, schools, factories, hospitals, clinics, language, and discourse. It is related to those obligations that are meant to maintain order. Thus, power has multiple apparatuses, and political power becomes intertwined with social, economic, intellectual, educational, and even medical power. Foucault coined the term "microphysics of power" to describe this network and these apparatuses. The study of the essence of power shifted from a top-down, hierarchical approach to an investigation of its mechanisms and apparatuses at the bottom. He concluded that power is both visible and invisible at the same time. It is "a productive network that permeates the entire social body, more than it is a negative institution whose function is to exercise repression"¹¹. In this sense, power is not only between the ruler and the ruled but is embodied in the simplest components, and it is not exercised only through repression but also employs other methods of subjugation.

Foucault was not only influenced by Nietzsche but also by a group of other philosophers, most notably the Italian philosopher Antonio Gramsci (1891–1937), who was one of the philosophers who criticized the Marxist theories of power, particularly their top-down and bottom-up aspects. Gramsci emphasized that the superstructure consists of "political structures

that include the state's administrative apparatus and its organizational structures and mechanisms, and civil structures that include a wide and extended network in society, yet it is invisible"¹². For Gramsci, power is an intertwined web of relationships within society; we find it in the authority of schools, corporations, families, various administrations, organizations, and religion, among others. It is from this that Foucault was influenced by the visible and invisible aspects of power. Foucault inverted the concepts of power, and his theses influenced many philosophers who were his contemporaries or came after him.

Among the philosophers who contributed to the concept of power is the French philosopher Pierre Bourdieu (1930–2002). He divided society into a set of fields: the economic field, the political field, the cultural field, and the field of power. The relationship between these fields lies in the intense conflict and competition among their members to extend influence and dominance. He states, "Power is not something localized in a specific place; rather, it is a system of intertwined relationships. We find that the entire structure of the social world must be taken into account to understand the mechanisms of domination and control"¹³. He developed numerous concepts related to his sociological project on power, most notably symbolic violence, symbolic power, and symbolic capital. We will elaborate on the latter two terms in the following pages of the study.

3. The Covert Cultural Systems of Power in Ibn Khaldun's Travels

Ibn Khaldun's travelogue is not merely a geographic account of lands and customs. It is a profound historical and political document that illuminates the dynamics of power during the eighth century AH. This

study will analyze the work through a socio-cultural critical lens, which examines a text not for its aesthetic qualities but for its relationship to **ideological, historical, political, social, economic, and intellectual influences**. This approach, following a meticulous textual analysis¹⁴, aims to uncover the mechanisms of power within the travelogue and to define Ibn Khaldun's own position within this power structure from a cultural-critical perspective.

3.1. The System of Confidential Advisors and Slander

According to Ibn Khaldun's theory of *'asabiyya* (group solidarity) as the basis for the rise of states, a ruler secures his reign by choosing a select group of trusted advisors from his own kinship group. These advisors, known as the *bitanah*, become a fundamental part of his governance, ensuring the stability of his rule and the security of his state. They are privy to state secrets and are consulted on matters of national welfare. The term *bitanah* literally refers to a person's inner circle, their confidant or secret keeper. This definition aligns with the political function of those who have private access to a ruler, provide him with confidential information about his subjects, and influence his decisions¹⁵. While some advisors may genuinely serve the ruler and his people, others might harbor hidden agendas¹⁶, seeking to sow discord and gain influence or power within the court.

Ibn Khaldun's travelogue frequently describes influential court figures—secretaries, chancellors, viziers, judges, and military commanders—who hold the power to influence the ruler's decisions. Their influence varies based on their proximity to the ruler. This inner circle functions as the hidden face of authority, possessing the power to change the course of state policy¹⁷. In the context of the travelogue, the system of

advisors and slander operates as a **covert cultural system** that underpins political governance and extends the mechanisms of the struggle for influence.

Ibn Khaldun himself was a prominent advisor who held numerous official positions and played an active role in political events. He openly admits to his efforts in both undermining and supporting rulers. For instance, he recounts his pivotal role in restoring Sultan Abu Salim to power. He leveraged his close ties with the elders of the Banu Marin tribe, convincing many of them to support Abu Salim. In recognition of this service, Abu Salim appointed him as his private secretary¹⁸, a position Ibn Khaldun describes: "He honored my past service and appointed me as his private secretary for his correspondence and official documents."¹⁹ This exemplifies how advisors' loyalties could shift with their own interests.

Ibn Khaldun also documents a personal conflict that occurred while he was serving as a secretary for Abu Inan. When the sultan's advisors slandered Ibn Khaldun by falsely accusing him of conspiring with the Almohad ruler in Bejaia to restore his kingdom, he was imprisoned. After Abu Inan's death, the vizier al-Hasan ibn Omar released Ibn Khaldun and reinstated him. This episode and others show how slander, as a common tool for settling scores and orchestrating coups, was used to undermine the status of intellectuals and scholars who gained favor at court. The travelogue reveals how many, including Ibn Khaldun himself, were imprisoned or exiled on fabricated charges of envy and jealousy. The most notable victim was the brilliant vizier and writer Lisan al-Din ibn al-Khatib, who, upon hearing of his flight from Granada to Morocco, was informed that "he feared his sultan due to the latter's overbearing nature and the abundant slander from his

advisors²⁰." Though Ibn Khaldun attempted to secure his friend's release from prison in Tlemcen, he was unsuccessful, and Lisan al-Din was ultimately killed while in custody.

The prevalence of slander created an atmosphere of distrust, feeding a culture of fear and caution. Ibn Khaldun's travelogue reveals that whenever he felt threatened by rumors, he would either request permission to go on a pilgrimage, travel to his hometown of Tunis, or retire from public life to focus on scholarship and writing. He alludes to this in his account of his time at the court of Abu Hammou Moussa ibn Yaghmurasan, the Sultan of the Zayyanid dynasty. He notes: "I stayed that night in detention. Then he released me the next day, and I went to the hermitage of the holy Sheikh Abu Madyan, settling near him, preferring solitude and dedication to knowledge."²¹

Interestingly, despite his firsthand experience as a key advisor, Ibn Khaldun's critique of power is rarely directed at the ruler himself. Instead, he blames "corrupt advisors," "the envious," or "the slanderers." This is a common strategy in courtly writing, designed to absolve the ruler of direct responsibility for acts of injustice or dismissal. It also serves to preserve Ibn Khaldun's own standing, leaving open the possibility of pardon or the failure of slanderous plots against him.

In essence, the system of advisors and slander was a covert system of power in the medieval Islamic world. It was a primary cause of internal conflicts, political instability, and ultimately contributed to the decline of Muslim civilization. The struggle for power, from the common man to the highest echelons of society, is a central theme in Ibn Khaldun's work, most famously illustrated in his theory of *'asabiyya* and his account of the rise and fall of dynasties.

3.2. The System of the Intellectual and Power: The Pen and the Sword

The sword and the pen are twin pillars of a state, essential for establishing rule, expanding influence, and ensuring security. Recognizing their importance, Ibn Khaldun dedicated an entire chapter in his *Muqaddimah* to their hierarchy, stating, "Know that the sword and the pen are both instruments for the ruler to aid his cause."²² A ruler first uses the **sword** to establish his dominion, then employs the **pen** to document his achievements and legitimize his rule. The pen's role, however, is not limited to mere record-keeping; it is also a tool for validation.

Sultan Abu Inan of Fez, for example, summoned scholars and writers from all over, driven by a desire to assimilate traditional intellectuals and ideologically subdue them²³. Ibn Khaldun was among these figures, whose knowledge was used to serve the interests of the dominant power. His writings often describe how rulers valued his intellectual and academic standing, reflecting their desire to gain legitimacy through the patronage of knowledge. However, this patronage was often a means of control. Intellectuals were not invited to think critically, but rather to endorse, issue religious rulings, and legitimize the ruler's authority. As Michel Foucault noted in *Discipline and Punish*, there is no power relationship without a corresponding field of knowledge, and no knowledge that does not presuppose and, at the same time, constitute power relationships²⁴.

The travelogue offers a complex portrait of the eighth-century intellectual. He is not just a conveyor of knowledge or an observer of events, but a direct participant in political affairs. Ibn Khaldun's pen, his analytical and rhetorical skills were employed to legitimize the ruler's decisions.

On several occasions, he was called upon to mediate political disputes, such as when he was sent to negotiate with the rebellious Berber tribes of Bejaia, who refused to pay taxes. He writes: "I went myself to the Berber tribes in the mountains of Bejaia who had refused to pay taxes for years. I entered their lands, violated their sanctuary, and took hostages to secure their obedience until I had collected the tribute from them."²⁵ In this instance, Ibn Khaldun's **pen** served the authority of the **sword**.

Moreover, Ibn Khaldun occasionally used his eloquence to incite subjects against a rival ruler, as he did in helping Sultan Abu Salim to the throne. He also used his pen and intellect to seek favor from rulers, praising them in poetry and prose. When he presented his book *Al-Ibar* to Sultan Abu al-Abbas of Tunis, he included a long poem, which reads in part:

*This is the Commander of the
Faithful, our Imam
In religion and in the world, to him is
our refuge
He seeks God's help in conquering
enemies
And upon the aid of his Lord, he
relies.*²⁶

This demonstrates how language became a representational tool for power. In Ibn Khaldun's writing, language does not just describe power; it reconstructs and represents it through subtle rhetorical devices. His frequent and lengthy mentions of genealogies and titles, his praises for the sultan, and his downplaying of serious events by attributing them to God's will are not merely stylistic choices. They are aesthetic systems that conceal tools for producing what Foucault calls "redistributed discourse." This means that language is not innocent; it is subject to

the authority of the ruler and transformed into a discourse of power itself.

Foucault's theories on discourse and power demonstrate that knowledge is not separate from authority; rather, it is a field where relationships of dominance and submission are born. Knowledge is not a simple accumulation of facts but a legitimizing discourse that is practiced, evaluated, and circulated under specific power-based conditions. The travelogue is a perfect example of this overlap, where Ibn Khaldun's intellectual position as a scholar, historian, and judge gives him a certain power, while his proximity to the ruler allows his knowledge to function within the power structure. This is evident in his public speeches in Cairo, where he portrayed the sultan as a heroic savior, a depiction that was often at odds with the reality of the time. While sultans built mosques and schools, ignorance, heresy, and poverty were rampant. Ibn Khaldun's speeches, therefore, served as a tool for the sultan's authority, polishing his image for the people and using rhetoric to manipulate their minds and emotions. This demonstrates that discourse itself can become a tool of power, subject to control because, as Foucault states, "the production of discourse in every society is at once controlled, selected, organized and redistributed by a certain number of procedures, whose role is to ward off its powers and its dangers."²⁷

Knowledge and culture can become a **symbolic threat** if a scholar opposes authority and refuses to serve it. If the state suspects a scholar's intentions, it will resort to exile, imprisonment, or even death, as exemplified by Ibn Khaldun's experience of being dismissed and exiled, and his friend Lisan al-Din ibn al-Khatib being killed in prison. The state's reaction is to control and domesticate language and knowledge to

serve its own ends. Given Ibn Khaldun's close relationship with authority, which enabled him to travel, study, and gain favor, he was expected to reciprocate by serving it. This aligns with Michel Foucault's assertion that "the more correct assumption would be that power is one of the conditions by which one can become a scholar" ²⁸. This reveals a fundamental tension in the relationship between the intellectual and authority in the Arab-Islamic context: knowledge is rewarded as long as it is obedient, but marginalized as soon as it demonstrates independence. This dynamic makes the travelogue a rich text, not only for its events but also for the symbolic web of relationships that govern what can be said. It sets the limits of legitimacy and determines what the intellectual is or is not permitted to say. According to Omar al-Tawer, "to achieve this goal [monitoring the production of discourse], discourse has been subjected to a set of rules that aim to confine, delimit, and fence it with internal and external procedures that reveal the containment of its internal logic and its connection to desire and power" ²⁹. From this perspective, discourse becomes an authoritative tool due to censorship; the intellectual does not have the right to say everything, only what authority permits.

The travelogue presents a portrait of the intellectual of that era as someone who promotes himself and his ideas in pursuit of status. At the beginning of the travelogue, Ibn Khaldun discusses his ancestors and the high positions they held. While this appears to be a clear expression of pride in his lineage, it conceals a deeper desire for power and status. He was even resentful of holding the position of a secretary in the court of Sultan Abu Inan because his ancestors had never held such a post. He alludes to this by stating, "He organized me into his scholarly council...

then employed me in his secretarial work, and in signing documents before him, much to my dislike, as I had never known such a thing for my ancestors" ³⁰. He considered this a personal slight and took the position reluctantly, as his ambition was far greater. He indicates this elsewhere in his travelogue: "I aspired, due to the impulsiveness of youth, to a rank higher than the one I was in" ³¹. This is further confirmed by his mention of his teachers and scholars who contributed to his education, after he finished recounting his lineage. The authority he possessed and his brilliance were inherited from his ancestors, and because of his eligibility and scholarly distinction, he wished to attain their stature. His fame quickly spread across the lands, and every sultan desired to have him in his court, for possessing knowledge meant possessing power and authority. Even the ruler of Bejaia was delighted by Ibn Khaldun's arrival in his emirate, saying, "The Sultan of Bejaia celebrated my arrival, and the people of his court rode out to meet me, while the townspeople swarmed upon me from all directions, stroking my robes and kissing my hands" ³².

In one of the most powerful scenes of the travelogue, the encounter between Ibn Khaldun and Timur represents the intersection of the scholar's authority with the sultan's might. Ibn Khaldun describes being summoned to Timur's tent, where the conqueror questioned him about his life and the affairs of the Maghreb. Timur then commanded him to document everything he knew about the region, stating, "I would like you to write for me a description of the entire Maghreb, its distant and nearby parts, its mountains and rivers, its villages and cities, as if I am observing it." ³³ This statement reveals a covert system where the power of knowledge is used as a tool for domination,

subjugation, and the conquest of nations. Despite his reputation for brute force and tyranny, Timur was keenly aware of the pen's role—a form of espionage—in geographical expansion and empire-building. In this instance, knowledge became a means of domination and a tool for global conquest. He brought with him on his campaign many scholars and engineers, which transformed Ibn Khaldun's symbolic capital—his knowledge of history, politics, and civilization, as well as his eloquence and literary skill—into a force for Timurid domination. This knowledge was used to anticipate the future and analyze the conditions of civilization to serve Timur's colonial and expansionist policies, turning the authority of knowledge into a means of solidifying the authority of power. This confirms Michel Foucault's assertion that there is no innocent knowledge. This is further underscored by the conversation that took place in Timur's presence, where Ibn Khaldun mentioned a prophecy circulated by the people of Fez—a prophecy that astrologers/intellectuals had helped spread—about the rise of a leader who would conquer the world. Ibn Khaldun mentioned this prophecy/knowledge to save his own life, which highlights the role of knowledge in entrenching power and dominance in society.

Based on the above, Ibn Khaldun sometimes used his authority to disseminate his ideas and build his reputation, while at other times he opposed authority, and at still others, he condemned certain state institutions—the inner circle of advisors and the judiciary. He would also praise the Sultan—the legendary hero—for his efforts in building mosques and schools. In doing so, he did not depart from the role of an ordinary intellectual who cheers for the ruling authority. This also reveals that knowledge

can be a source of threat if it conflicts with the interests of the Sultan or his inner circle.

The authority of knowledge was transformed into a tool for division among intellectuals in the pursuit of power and influence. We see in Ibn Khaldun's travelogue how strong friendships between scholars turn into bitter enmity due to envy and jealousy, driven by the desire for favor and authority in the courts of sultans. We witnessed how the friendship between Ibn Khaldun and the vizier Lisan al-Din ibn al-Khatib turned into a hateful enmity filled with plotting. The correspondence included in Ibn Khaldun's travelogue reveals the nature of their relationship, as they exchanged news of Andalusia and the Maghreb, and expressed their sorrow over the state of the Islamic lands and their feelings of brotherhood and love. However, the system of ego and self-promotion eventually surfaced at the expense of virtuous values and morals.

▪ Symbolic Power

The travelogue's discourse restructures the concept of power based on what Pierre Bourdieu termed **symbolic power**, which he defines as "the capacity to constitute the given by means of verbal utterances, a capacity for clarification and persuasion, for establishing or transforming a vision of the world and, consequently, a capacity to transform the world itself by transforming the perception of it." This is a "quasi-magical power that makes it possible to obtain the equivalent of what is obtained by force (whether physical or economic) thanks to its capacity to mobilize.³⁴" Symbolic power's legitimacy stems from the other party's submission. Bourdieu affirms its effectiveness only when its influence is recognized: "This power only functions if it is recognized."³⁵

From this perspective, Ibn Khaldun possessed symbolic power. He leveraged his academic status, or what Bourdieu called "symbolic capital," to quell strife and facilitate diplomatic relations. He was frequently called upon to intervene in disputes with rebellious tribes and to mediate between feuding princes. In these roles, he would use Islamic jurisprudence to reconcile parties, or, in his diplomatic missions between the Sultan of the Banu al-Ahmar and the King of Castile, he would appeal to reason and foresight. In his embassy from the Sultan of Egypt to Timur, he adopted a softer approach. This demonstrates that Ibn Khaldun deployed his symbolic capital strategically, depending on the situation. This can also be seen as "psychological power," defined as "a person's ability to impose his will on others due to his strong personality, steadfastness, good judgment, and captivating rhetoric."³⁶

Evidence of Ibn Khaldun's symbolic capital includes his education under the most renowned scholars and his inheritance of symbolic capital from his ancestors, the Banu Khaldun of Andalusia. Early in his travelogue, he lists his forefathers and their prestigious positions, aiming to follow in their footsteps and consolidate his own intellectual authority and symbolic capital. His phrases like "he summoned me," "he included me," "he employed me," and "he singled me out" reflect the power and influence he had gained through his academic standing. His description of his arrival in Granada to meet Sultan Ibn al-Ahmar and his vizier, Lisan al-Din ibn al-Khatib, further highlights this: "The Sultan was delighted by my arrival, and prepared a residence for me in his palaces, with its furnishings and supplies. He sent his special entourage to meet me, in honor and kindness; then I

entered before him, and he fittingly received me."³⁷ This demonstrates that Ibn Khaldun was not an ordinary visitor but a renowned figure whose fame had spread throughout the Islamic world. The Sultan even entrusted him with a diplomatic mission to the King of Castile.

Ibn Khaldun also used his symbolic capital to serve his political ambitions and gain favor from rulers. When he was appointed to lead the judiciary and the state-sponsored schools, he would deliver ceremonial speeches, often beginning with prayers for the Sultan's success, thereby publicly endorsing central authority. At the end of his speeches, his audience would regard him with reverence and respect for his profound knowledge and literary skill.

However, Ibn Khaldun did not solely use his symbolic capital to serve the ruling class or his own ego. He also employed it to take a stand against certain unlawful practices within the judiciary, demonstrating a degree of independence from the dominant power. He attempted to disseminate his values and principles, grounding them in his religious convictions and moral ethics, despite repeated attempts by slanderers to have him removed from his post. His awareness of Timur's underlying motives, evidenced by the conqueror's repeated questions about the Maghreb, led him to send a message to the Sultan of Morocco, informing him of their discussions. This action reflects the true role of an intellectual in his society. His active role in serving just causes—restoring rights, resolving conflicts, and seeking to impose justice among social classes, as well as his rejection of the Mongol ruler's barbarism—can be seen as fitting the profile of an organic intellectual, as defined by Antonio Gramsci. Gramsci argued that the new intellectual's approach "is no longer based on rhetoric,

which is a temporary, external motivator of feelings and emotions. Rather, it has become based on active participation in practical life as a builder and organizer of it.³⁸ The intellectual's role is to build a solid foundation for their social class by shaping its ideas and perceptions of societal issues, thereby entering into a struggle with other classes to impose their ideological dominance. This is evident in Ibn Khaldun's intellectual conflict with his opponents when he took on the role of judge—a struggle between a class that served its own interests and one that played an active role in society. His knowledge, wisdom, and language became tools to expose the ruling practices, goals, and ideology of others, in addition to his assigned duties in the judiciary, education, and diplomacy.

Ibn Khaldun's role as an organic intellectual went beyond simply exposing corruption within the judiciary. He also provided valuable advice to rulers. He went beyond mere description, offering analytical insights into politics and human civilization. This is evident in his speeches on his theory of *'asabiyya* at the inauguration of schools and hospices, where he analyzed the causes of the rise and fall of states. This is also apparent in his conversations with Timur about monarchy, geography, and civilization.

In the travelogue, the authority of culture and knowledge is not neutral; it is a mechanism of power. However, it can also become a source of power in Ibn Khaldun's hands. His knowledge of history, politics, and civilization became a rhetorical force that enabled him to influence sultans. He writes of his experience with the ruler of Bejaia: "He ordered the state officials to visit me early in the morning, and I took charge of the burden of his kingdom, and I exhausted my efforts in managing his affairs and governing his

authority, and he put me in charge of the Friday sermon in the Al-Qasaba mosque.³⁹" In this instance, culture and knowledge became symbolic capital that their owner can invest to gain status and influence. Ibn Khaldun skillfully used his knowledge to advance socially and politically. He also influenced tribal leaders, supporting some and turning others against the ruler, and contributed to decision-making, as he did with Timur, asking for amnesty for the city's inhabitants. From a Gramscian perspective, the travelogue reveals that knowledge for Ibn Khaldun was not an intellectual luxury but an organic tool to serve just causes. Ibn Khaldun, the scholar, judge, and historian, was not just a narrator of power but a part of its symbolic and intellectual apparatus, producing a discourse that reshaped the relationship between the ruler and the intellectual, between the pen and the sword.

3.3. The System of Religion and Politics: The Sacralization of Power and the Politicization of Religion

A. The Sacralization of Power: The Image of the Sultan as God's Shadow on Earth

The concept of sacralizing power in the medieval Islamic era is rooted in the saying, "The sultan is God's shadow on earth." This belief made the sultan God's appointed representative for maintaining order and achieving justice. Power thus acquired a sacred, religious dimension, transforming it from a human tool for managing people's affairs into a metaphysical instrument that derives its legitimacy from a divine mandate.

In his speeches upon taking charge of teaching at the Qamhiyya school, Ibn Khaldun praises the Mamluk sultans of Egypt, saying that God "chose for it kings who raise its pillars, correct its crookedness by establishing policy, and fend off with their decisive will whoever seeks to harm or plot

against it.⁴⁰ In another sermon, he affirms this, stating that God chose for his people "kings whom He created with a natural inclination for justice and guided to uphold His word. Then He favored them with an abundance of provision and power, deriving their authority on earth from His power."⁴¹ In this sense, the sultan is considered a worldly manifestation of divine justice who enforces God's law. This view of the ruler perpetuated the idea of a theocratic rule—a government that claims legitimacy from God—combining worldly authority with religious legitimacy. He becomes the ruler who can manage his state and subjects and protect the Islamic faith and its laws.

Based on this, Ibn Khaldun describes Sultan Barquq as "God's mercy that protects His creation, and His shadow that shields His servants with justice and truth... Entrusting his affairs with sincerity to the guardian of this world and the hereafter, the supporter of the monotheists, the one who raises the pillars of faith, the protector of the caliphate of the believers, the Sultan of Muslims Abu Sa'id... And He made him the guardian and helper for the affairs of the Muslims."⁴² The ruler embodies both spiritual and political legitimacy, which forces the subjects to recognize his authority. Consequently, "the ruler's will was absolute and limited only by God's will, meaning that the legitimacy of that will was derived from a divine right, not from the people's consent. Thus, the judicial wisdom was that obedience to the ruler's will was a necessary duty, even if the ruler was unjust. Therefore, there was no justification for a revolution against him."⁴³ To rebel against him was to rebel against God's law and violate its boundaries.

Ibn Khaldun's travelogue consistently portrays the sultan as a ruler who derives his power from divine providence. Phrases like

"may God support him" and "may God reward his white hand" illustrate this view. The sultan is surrounded by a spiritual aura that strengthens his authority and legitimizes his rule. Because of his wise governance, he becomes a legendary hero. This image is prominent in Ibn Khaldun's ceremonial speeches when he was appointed to teach at the schools and hospices built by the Mamluk sultans. The sultan, "the Victorious King, the Mighty Conqueror, the Just and Pure, the one who manages the affairs of Islam,"⁴⁴ possesses the qualities that qualify him to be God's shadow on earth and His vicegerent in managing the affairs of His people. The use of attributes that are also among God's most beautiful names highlights the ruler's elevated status, suggesting a similarity between God and the sultan—a resemblance without being an exact match⁴⁵.

This relationship between the ruler and his subjects, based on his religious and worldly legitimacy and his legendary status, reveals a hierarchical dynamic. The ruler's power is divinely sanctioned, which allows him to elevate himself above the people. This is reflected in the very meaning of the word "sultan," which implies material power, superiority over others, and the use of coercion and force to instill fear⁴⁶. The sultan, as the nucleus and center of the state, commands, legislates, permits, imprisons, requests, and pardons, while the subjects obey. This absolute authority is sanctioned by the religious legitimacy of his role as "God's shadow on earth" and is supported by his kinship group and advisors. This model aligns with the "paternalistic" theory proposed by the Palestinian thinker Hicham Sharabi (1927-2005), which portrays the ruler as a father who controls his children (the subjects) or a sheikh who leads his tribe. The subjects must obey because they can never

match his wisdom, foresight, and power⁴⁷. This relationship is clearly evident in Timur's dominance, as he could command his followers with a mere gesture. Ibn Khaldun, with all his symbolic power, bowed and kissed his hand upon entering to gain his favor and succeed in his diplomatic mission. This same ruler, who was feared by many and committed atrocities, had a limp and could not walk long distances without being carried, which prompted Ibn Khaldun to implicitly marvel at his power despite his physical disability: "His right knee was afflicted by an arrow that struck him during a raid in his youth, so he drags it when walking short distances, but men carry him on their hands for long distances, and the kingdom belongs to God, who gives it to whom He wills from among His servants."⁴⁸ This belief in divine right, which was widespread at the time, legitimized tyranny and corruption. The corruption led to a deterioration of political, social, economic, and intellectual conditions.

The worst consequence of corruption was the proliferation of conflicts among Muslims. Each faction, convinced of its religious legitimacy, granted itself the right to the Caliphate, and everyone waited for an opportunity to overthrow the other. This was ultimately due to the human instinct for leadership and power, which led individuals to topple their own brother and separate from their own father. This is precisely what happened when Abu Inan overthrew his father⁴⁹, Abu al-Hasan, the ruler of the Marinid dynasty. Ibn Khaldun notes this, stating, "The Maghreb rebelled against the Sultan, and his son Abu Inan became independent." Abu Inan then exiled his brother, Abu Salim, who later demanded his father's throne and incited the tribes against his nephew and the vizier in charge of state affairs, with his secretary Ibn Marzuq and Ibn

Khaldun himself supporting his popular cause. Ibn Khaldun also narrated the actions of the ruler of Constantine and Bona, who "burdened the state with his severity and strength beyond its capacity, through tyranny and striking the hands of the exploitative Bedouins."⁵⁰

The reach of corruption even extended to the holiest place on Earth, Mecca, due to the tyranny and legitimization of power. Ibn Khaldun recounts the pilgrims' suffering at the sacred house, noting the "corruption of the water systems and fountains prepared for God's guests and pilgrims of His House, to the point that it was claimed chaos had reached Cairo for days, and turmoil had become widespread in its streets and markets."⁵¹ This was all due to tyranny and corrupt rule.

Ultimately, the travelogue exposed the cultural structure that legitimized authority through a religious lens in medieval Islamic history, as well as the resulting despotism, injustice, and corruption. This analysis helps explain the deplorable conditions in all aspects of Muslim life during that period.

B. The Politicization of Religion: The Judiciary as an Instrument of Power

Authority does not only exert its dominance through coercion; it also mobilizes institutions to regulate the behavior of its subjects. This is the purpose of the judiciary, which, according to Michel Foucault, is a disciplinary apparatus that the judge uses to control the individual's behavior to "make him more docile in proportion as he is more useful."⁵² This is achieved by creating laws and regulations to produce "submissive and trained bodies, docile bodies"⁵³ that serve authority.

In the medieval Islamic era, neither religious authority nor the judiciary was separate from politics. Politics was based on

religion and drew its legitimacy from religious texts. The sultan would delegate judicial tasks to the judge, who, in turn, would serve the sultan and support his decisions to consolidate his rule as "God's shadow on earth, to whom the weak seek refuge and through whom the oppressed are victorious."⁵⁴ The judge's role was to enforce justice by controlling and monitoring his subjects' behavior. The judiciary thus became a political tool, transforming its religious purpose into a political one. Ibn Khaldun notes this when he was appointed to the judiciary after the previous Maliki judge was dismissed by the Sultan of Egypt and Syria: "The Sultan singled me out for this position, as a mark of my standing and a way of exalting my name. I spoke to him about the difficulty of the post, but he insisted on my appointment, and he granted me a robe of honor in his court, and sent some of his high-ranking officials to seat me in the court of justice."⁵⁵ The words 'singled me out,' 'insisted,' 'sent,' 'high-ranking officials,' and 'seated me' all highlight the relationship between the judiciary and the political authority.

The politicization of the judiciary is also evident in the fact that sultans appointed judges. By order of the Sultan, Ibn Khaldun himself was appointed and dismissed from the position of Maliki chief judge six times, illustrating the paternalistic role of the sultan who appoints and removes whomever he wishes. The judiciary was thus transformed into a functional tool in the hands of the sultan. The Mamluk sultans appointed four judges, one for each of the four schools of jurisprudence (Maliki, Hanafi, Shafi'i, Hanbali), to settle disputes and ensure justice. This indicates that the judiciary was subject to the ruler's authority, even as it was also intended to ensure justice. The politicization

of the judiciary was intended to serve the public interest as long as it aligned with the ruler's goals and prevented strife. However, this also led to corruption within the institution itself. Corrupt officials used the diversity of the schools of jurisprudence as a pretext to issue legal rulings from unqualified judges. Ibn Khaldun notes that "the pen of the fatwa (legal ruling) in this city is free, and its reins are loose. Each litigant pulls a different rope and uses it to gain victory over his opponent and humiliate him. The jurist grants him his wish, following him through the differences of opinion, so the rulings contradict and oppose each other."⁵⁶ This led to chaos and instability due to corruption and the abuse of power.

Ibn Khaldun repeatedly asserts his integrity in performing his judicial duties, relying on his extensive knowledge and insight. He sought to reconcile litigants, verify their claims, and discredit false testimonies, rejecting haste and basing his rulings on religious principles. He writes: "I fulfilled my duty to the best of my ability in God's judgments, never fearing reproach for speaking the truth, and never yielding to status or power... turning away from intercessions and connections from both sides."⁵⁷ This statement implicitly critiques the corruption of the judiciary at the time, which had strayed from its primary function of upholding justice. Ibn Khaldun presents two contradictory images of the judiciary: one an ideal, based on justice and law, which he tried to practice, and the other, run by favor and power. He notes that many litigants "were mixed with the amirs, taught the Quran, and served as prayer leaders, clothing themselves in piety. People would trust them, and they would give them a share of their influence to intercede for them with the judges. The disease was difficult to cure."⁵⁸

This highlights that the judiciary was run by favoritism in its rulings and that religion was used as a means to abuse power for personal gain.

Other judicial abuses included false testimonies, bribery, and the appropriation of charitable endowments, which were so vast and numerous that their management became a source of corruption. The manipulation of different schools of jurisprudence for issuing legal opinions was another issue. All this occurred while "the rulers were restrained from criticizing them, and overlooked their faults, because they feigned allegiance to the men of power."⁵⁹ Corruption did not only plague the subjects but also the rulers, and the judiciary was corrupt because of its dependence on the political authority.

Overall, the travelogue can be read as Ibn Khaldun's defense against the accusations he faced during his time as a judge. His narrative restructures the events to favor religion and morality, portraying the honest judge against the corruption of the judiciary and the political establishment. He attempted to reform the judiciary by restructuring it according to religious authority. Through the judicial power granted to him by the sultan, he exercised control over the subjects. This confirms Foucault's view that power is a series of apparatuses. Ibn Khaldun used his knowledge to monitor the people through the judiciary and the sultan. He, in turn, was monitored by slanderers who conspired against him, leading to his removal from office. The sultan granted him leave to perform the pilgrimage, which was a way to alleviate his suffering after losing his wife and children in a shipwreck.

To conclude, to understand how power operated in the medieval era through Ibn Khaldun's travelogue, we must consider Foucault's view that "power is exercised

rather than possessed; it is not the 'privilege,' acquired or preserved, of the dominant class, but the overall effect of its strategic positions—an overall effect that is not only a result but also the instrument of its positions."⁶⁰ According to Foucault, everyone exercises power: the sultan, the intellectual (Ibn Khaldun), the judge, the advisors, the slanderers, the kin group (*'asabiyya*), the people, religion, and language. Everyone is involved in the power game, whether consciously or not.

CONCLUSION

Following an examination of the covert systems that lie beneath the surface of overt power, the study has reached several key conclusions:

- **The Tools of Power:** In the medieval Islamic era, the Sultan and state relied on advisors (*bitanah*), culture and knowledge, the sacralization of power, and the politicization of the judiciary.

- **The Role of Advisors:** The inner circle of advisors viewed power as an end in itself, using slander to overthrow rivals who did not align with their interests. These individuals formed alliances that either swore allegiance to the ruling authority or threatened its very existence. The travelogue presents a vivid portrayal of the hidden mechanisms of political power in the medieval period, revealing the critical role of the Sultan's entourage in decision-making. This shows that the travelogue contains covert systems, where the hidden authority of the advisors and slander acts as a parallel institution to that of the Sultan. Ibn Khaldun's deep analysis of the events he witnessed during his travels helped him develop his theory of *'asabiyya*, which he mentioned in his travelogue and explored in detail in his *Muqaddimah*.

- **The Intellectual and Power:** The ruling authority attempted to co-opt organic

intellectuals, who possessed symbolic capital, into its service. It would exile, dismiss, or even execute those who refused. While the travelogue shows how an intellectual might yield to the temptation of power, it also reveals the authority of the organic intellectual who used his knowledge to serve the people and his diplomatic skill to serve both the subjects and the Sultan. From this perspective, the travelogue is not only a political document but also a narrative that chronicles Ibn Khaldun's relationship with the power structure over time and space. It highlights the intellectual's struggle between his own ambition and the authority of the ruler and the slanderers, and shows his strategic withdrawal when he sensed danger.

▪ **The Sacralization of Politics:** The practice of sacralizing politics by portraying the Sultan as "God's shadow on earth" created a sacred aura around the ruler that made it forbidden to oppose him. Rebelling against him was seen as an act against religion and divine law. This use of religion to legitimize power and politics led to a great deal of unrest during that period.

▪ **The Politicization of the Judiciary:** The judiciary was made into a tool to serve the ruling authority. As an organic intellectual, Ibn Khaldun diagnosed the corruption of the judicial institution, its subservience to the Sultan, and the moral decay of judges who accepted bribes to serve private interests. This corruption had dire consequences, and the breakdown of the judiciary was one of the key factors that hindered social development and contributed to the decline of Muslim societies after a long period of prosperity. This is a pattern that can still be observed in today's world, as conditions have not changed significantly since then.

▪ **Overall Perspective:** By analyzing the travelogue through socio-cultural concepts

formulated by Foucault, Gramsci, Bourdieu, and Hicham Sharabi, this study shows that Ibn Khaldun acted as an organic intellectual. He was not only connected to power structures through political loyalty but also through his possession of symbolic and intellectual capital. He sought to preserve this capital in a turbulent era.

▪ **A Symbolic Text:** In this context, *Ibn Khaldun's Travelogue* is not merely a record of a journey; it is a symbolic text that acts as a mirror of power. It encodes positions and judgments within a seemingly familiar discourse, yet it is deeply tied to a symbolic system hidden beneath the surface. The travelogue thus exposes the other face of power, revealing that it is exercised by all individuals and institutions in society.

References

Primary Sources

1. The Holy Quran, narration of Warsh from Nafi'.

Sources

1. Abd al-Rahman ibn Muhammad al-Hadrami al-Ishbili. *Ibn Khaldun's Travelogue*. Edited by Muhammad ibn Tawit al-Tanji. 1st ed. Beirut, Lebanon: Dar al-Kutub al-Ilmiyah, 2004.

Dictionaries

1. Ibn Manzur, Jamal al-Din Muhammad ibn Mukarram al-Ifriqi al-Masri. *Lisan al-Arab*. n.d. Beirut, Lebanon: Dar Sader.

2. Saliba, Jamil. *The Philosophical Dictionary: In Arabic, French, English, and Latin Terms*. n.d. Beirut, Lebanon: Dar al-Kitab al-Lubnani, 1982.

Arabic References

1. Ahmad ibn 'Alī ibn Ḥajar al-'Asqalānī, *Fath al-Bārī: Commentary on Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī*, n.ed., Dār al-Ma'rifah, Beirut, Lebanon, 1379 AH.

2. Jawdat Muḥammad Ibrāhīm Abū Ḥaṣ, *The Philosophical Perspective of Power in Michel Foucault: A Study in Political and Social Philosophy*, 1st ed., Arab Center for Research and Policy Studies, Beirut, Lebanon, 2017.

3. 'Abd al-Rahmān ibn Khaldūn, *Al-Muqaddimah*, ed. 'Abdallāh Muḥammad al-Darwīsh, 1st ed., Dār Ya'rub, Damascus, Syria, 2004.
4. Dhākīr 'Abd al-Nabī, *The Arab Journey to Europe, America, and Russia during the Nineteenth and Twentieth Centuries*, 1st ed., al-Suwaīdī Publishing and Distribution, Abu Dhabi, United Arab Emirates, 2005.
5. Ṭāhā 'Abd al-Rahmān, *Language and Balance, or the Multiplication of the Intellect*, 1st ed., Arab Cultural Center, Beirut, Lebanon, 1998.
6. 'Alī ibn Aḥmad ibn Nūr al-Dīn al-'Azīzī, *Al-Sirāj al-Munīr: Commentary on al-Jāmi' al-Ṣaghīr of the Prophet, the Bringer of Glad Tidings and Warner*, 1st ed., al-Khayriyyah Press, Egypt, 1304 AH.
7. 'Alī Mabrouk, *Power and the Sacred: The Dialectic of the Political and the Cultural in Islam*, n.ed., Hindawi Foundation, United Kingdom, 2024.
8. 'Alī ibn Muḥammad ibn Ḥabīb al-Māwardī, *Al-Aḥkām al-Sulṭāniyyah wa-l-Wilāyāt al-Dīniyyah*, ed. Aḥmad Mubārak al-Baghdādī, 1st ed., Dār Ibn Qutaybah Library, Kuwait, 1989.
9. Nawāl 'Abd al-Rahmān al-Shawābiqah, *Andalusian and Maghribi Travels until the End of the Ninth Century AH*, 1st ed., Dār al-Ma'mūn for Publishing and Distribution, Amman, Jordan, 2008.

Translated References

1. Gramsci, Antonio. *Prison Notebooks*. Translated by Adel Ghunaym. n.d. Cairo, Egypt: Dar al-Mustaqbal al-Arabi, 1994.
2. Bourdieu, Pierre. *Symbolic Power*. Translated by Abd al-Salam bin Abdul Ali. 3rd ed. Casablanca, Morocco: Toubkal Publishing, 2007.

3. Balandier, Georges. *Political Anthropology*. Translated by Ali al-Masri. 2nd ed. Beirut, Lebanon: University Foundation for Studies, Publishing, and Distribution, 2007.
4. Sharabi, Hisham. *The Patriarchal System and the Problem of Underdevelopment in Arab Society*. Translated by Mahmoud Sharayh. 1st ed. Beirut, Lebanon: Center for Arab Unity Studies, 1992.
5. Revolon d'Allones, Myriam. *Sultan of Beginnings: A Study in Authority*. Translated by Sa'id Matar. Revised by Maurice Abu Nadir. 1st ed. Beirut, Lebanon: Center for Arab Unity Studies, 2012.
6. Foucault, Michel. *Discipline and Punish: The Birth of the Prison*. Translated by Ali Muqallad. Revised by Mutaa Safadi. n.d. Beirut, Lebanon: National Development Center, 1990.
7. Foucault, Michel. *The Order of Discourse*. Translated by Muhammad Sibila. N.d. Beirut, Lebanon: Dar al-Tanwir for Printing and Publishing, n.d.

Journals and Periodicals

1. Bourdieu, Pierre. "Between Karl Marx and Max Weber: A Dialogue with Pierre Bourdieu." *Al-Fikr al-Arabi Journal*, no. 37, 1985.
2. al-Tawer, Omar. "Discourse as Authority and Subject to Authority: A Foucaultian Vision." *Al-Ma'rifah Journal*, no. 16, June 2024.
3. al-Ansari, Yusuf Abdullah. "Cultural Criticism and the Questions of the Recipient." *Faculty of Arts and Human Sciences, Critical Studies Track*, 2008. Visited: August 31, 2025, 10:25 PM. Article link: <https://adab.arabepro.com/t251-topic>

¹ al-Shawabkeh, Nawal Abd al-Rahman. *Andalusian and Maghrebi Journeys until the End of the Ninth Century AH*. 1st ed. Amman, Jordan: Dar al-Ma'mun for Publishing and Distribution, 2008, p. 240.

² For further reading, see: Ibn Khaldun, Abd al-Rahman ibn Muhammad al-Hadrami al-Ishbili. *Ibn Khaldun's Travelogue*. Edited by Muhammad ibn Tawit al-Tanji. 1st ed. Beirut, Lebanon: Dar

al-Kutub al-Ilmiyah, 2004, Introduction of the editor, pp. 12-26.

³] Abd al-Nabi, Dhakir. *The Arab Journey to Europe, America, and the Russian Lands during the Nineteenth and Twentieth Centuries*. 1st ed. Abu Dhabi, UAE: al-Suwaīdī Publishing and Distribution, 2005, p. 87.

⁴ Ibid., p. 94.

⁵ Ibn Manzur, Jamal al-Din Muhammad ibn Mukarram al-Ifriqi al-Masri. *Lisan al-Arab*. n.d. Beirut, Lebanon: Dar Sader, n.d., vol. 7, pp. 320, 321.

⁶ Saliba, Jamil. *The Philosophical Dictionary: In Arabic, French, English, and Latin Terms*. n.d. Beirut, Lebanon: Dar al-Kitab al-Lubnani, 1982, vol. 1, p. 670.

⁷ Balandier, Georges. *Political Anthropology*. Translated by Ali al-Masri. 2nd ed. Beirut, Lebanon: University Foundation for Studies, Publishing, and Distribution, 2007, p. 54.

⁸ Revolon d'Allones, Myriam. *Sultan of Beginnings: A Study in Authority*. Translated by Sa'id Matar. Revised by Maurice Abu Nadir. 1st ed. Beirut, Lebanon: Center for Arab Unity Studies, 2012, p. 07.

⁹ al-Mawardi, Ali ibn Muhammad ibn Habib. *Al-Ahkam al-Sultaniyyah wa al-Wilayat al-Diniyyah*. Edited by Ahmad Mubarak al-Baghdadi. 1st ed. Kuwait: Maktabat Dar Ibn Qutaybah, 1989, p. 03.

¹⁰ Ibid., p. 22.

¹¹ Foucault, Michel. *The Order of Discourse*. Translated by Muhammad Sibila. n.d. Beirut, Lebanon: Dar al-Tanwir for Printing and Publishing, n.d., pp. 63, 64.

¹² Abu Has, Jawdah Muhammad Ibrahim. *The Philosophical Perspective of Authority in Michel Foucault: A Study in Political and Social Philosophy*. 1st ed. Beirut, Lebanon: Arab Center for Research and Policy Studies, 2017, p. 69.

¹³ Bourdieu, Pierre. "Between Karl Marx and Max Weber: A Dialogue with Pierre Bourdieu." *Al-Fikr al-Arabi Journal*, no. 37, 1985, p. 72.

*Hidden violence that is veiled, not direct, but takes the form of symbols, signs, and media, making its victims willingly submit to this type of violence without even realizing it

¹⁴ al-Ansari, Yusuf Abdullah. "Cultural Criticism and the Questions of the Recipient." Faculty of Arts and Human Sciences, Critical Studies Track, 2008. Accessed: August 31, 2025, 10:25 PM. Article link: <https://adab.arabepro.com/t251-topic>.

¹⁵ Ibn Manzur, Muhammad ibn Mukarram. *Lisan al-Arab*. vol. 13, p. 55.

¹⁶ al-Asqalani, Ahmad ibn Ali ibn Hajar. *Fath al-Bari: Commentary on Sahih al-Bukhari*. n.d. Beirut, Lebanon: Dar al-Ma'rifah, 1379 AH, vol. 13, p. 190. *He is Ibrahim ibn Ali ibn Uthman, one of the Marinid sultans. Born in 735 AH and died in 762 AH. His brother, Sultan Abu Inan, exiled him to Andalusia to keep him away from

the throne. He returned to Fez to claim his father's throne after his brother's assassination and his five-year-old son's ascension. Abu Salim then rebelled against him and took power

¹⁷ Ibn Khaldun's Travelogue, p. 74.

¹⁸ Ibid., p. 75.

*He is Faris ibn Ali, the son of Sultan Abu al-Hasan, who succeeded his father after his death. He was born in 729 AH and was assassinated in 759 AH by his vizier, al-Hasan ibn Umar.

¹⁹ Ibn Khaldun's Travelogue, p. 80.

²⁰ Ibid., p. 124.

²¹ Ibid., p. 121.

²² Ibn Khaldun, Abd al-Rahman. *The Muqaddimah*. Edited by Abdullah Muhammad al-Darwish. 1st ed. Damascus, Syria: Dar Ya'rub, 2004, vol. 1, p. 442.

²³ Gramsci, Antonio. *Prison Notebooks*. Translated by Adel Ghunaym. n.d. Cairo, Egypt: Dar al-Mustaqbal al-Arabi, 1994, p. 26.

²⁴ Foucault, Michel. *Discipline and Punish: The Birth of the Prison*. Translated by Ali Muqallad. Revised and presented by Mutaa Safadi. n.d. Beirut, Lebanon: National Development Center, 1990, p. 63.

²⁵ Ibn Khaldun's Travelogue, p. 96.

²⁶ Ibid., p. 192.

²⁷ Foucault, Michel. *The Order of Discourse*, p. 04.

²⁸ Foucault, Michel. *Discipline and Punish: The Birth of the Prison*, p. 63.

²⁹ al-Tawer, Omar. "Discourse as Authority and Subject to Authority: A Foucaultian Vision." *Al-Ma'rifah Journal*, no. 16, June 2024, p. 849.

³⁰ Ibn Khaldun's Travelogue, p. 67.

³¹ Ibid., p. 80.

³² Ibid., p. 95.

³³ Ibid., p. 290.

³⁴ Bourdieu, Pierre. *Symbolic Power*. Translated by Abd al-Salam bin Abdul Ali. 3rd ed. Casablanca, Morocco: Toubkal Publishing, 2007, p. 56.

³⁵ Ibid., same page.

³⁶ Saliba, Jamil. *The Philosophical Dictionary*, p. 670.

³⁷ Ibn Khaldun's Travelogue, p. 85.

³⁸ Gramsci, Antonio. *Prison Notebooks*, p. 26.

³⁹ Ibn Khaldun's Travelogue, p. 95

⁴⁰ Ibid., p. 223.

⁴¹ Ibid., p. 228.

⁴² Ibid., pp. 228, 229.

⁴³ Sharabi, Hisham. *The Patriarchal System and the Problem of Underdevelopment in Arab Society*. Translated by Mahmoud Sharayh. 1st ed.

Beirut, Lebanon: Center for Arab Unity Studies, 1992, p. 72.

⁴⁴ Ibn Khaldun's Travelogue, p. 229.

⁴⁵ Mabrouk, Ali. Authority and the Sacred: The Dialectic of the Political and Cultural in Islam. n.d. UK: Hindawi Foundation, 2024, pp. 27, 28.

⁴⁶ See: Abd al-Rahman, Taha. Al-Lisan wa al-Mizan, or the Proliferation of the Intellect. 1st ed. Beirut, Lebanon: Arab Cultural Center, 1998, p. 132.

⁴⁷ For more, see: Sharabi, Hisham. The Patriarchal System and the Problem of Underdevelopment in Arab Society, pp. 59, 60.

⁴⁸ Ibn Khaldun's Travelogue, p. 299.

⁴⁹ Ibid., p. 49.

⁵⁰ Ibid., p. 115.

⁵¹ Ibid., same page.

⁵² Foucault, Michel. Discipline and Punish: The Birth of the Prison, p. 157.

⁵³ Ibid., same page.

⁵⁴ al-Azizi, Ali ibn Ahmad ibn Nur al-Din. Al-Siraj al-Munir: Commentary on Al-Jami' al-Saghir fi Hadith al-Bashir al-Nadhir. 1st ed. Cairo, Egypt: al-Matba'ah al-Khayriyah, 1304 AH, vol. 3, p. 234.

⁵⁵ Ibn Khaldun's Travelogue, p. 204.

⁵⁶ Ibid., p. 206.

⁵⁷ Ibid., same page.

⁵⁸ Ibid., p. 205.

⁵⁹ Ibid., same page.

⁶⁰ Foucault, Michel. Discipline and Punish: The Birth of the Prison, p. 63.